A Baseline, Not a Prediction

A short guide to noticing change in Dad's everyday life without jumping to conclusions.

Dad takes a little longer with some things than he used to. Or perhaps he always did. It's hard to say, because nobody wrote down how things were, and there was no reason to.

This guide explains why a dated description of his ordinary days is worth more than a guess about what comes next, and what belongs in one. It describes a habit. It doesn't size anyone up.

A baseline, not a prediction

A baseline is a description of how Dad manages now, with a date on it. That's all it is. Nothing has to be wrong for it to be worth having, and it says nothing about what comes next.

It starts with what he does well. AARP's planning guide for families introduces its own checklist as a way to start the conversation about what is most important to your loved ones and what strengths they bring. [1]

Prediction is the part to leave out. How much care people need, and for how long, varies from person to person and often changes over time, according to the federal Administration for Community Living. AARP's guide says it from the family's side: how a loved one's needs unfold may differ from what you expected. [2] [1]

- Describe an ordinary week, not his best day or his hardest.
- Slow change only shows when there are two dated pages to set side by side.
- Leave out where you think things are heading. The page is about now.

Everyday function, in plain words

Professionals sort ordinary life into two lists. The first is the basic personal tasks, sometimes called activities of daily living or ADLs: bathing, dressing, using the toilet, transferring to or from a bed or chair, caring for incontinence, and eating. [3]

The second is the everyday tasks, sometimes called instrumental activities of daily living or IADLs: housework, managing money, taking medication, preparing and cleaning up after meals, shopping, using the telephone, caring for pets, and responding to emergency alerts such as fire alarms. [3]

AARP's guide describes how a family's help may begin: with driving a loved one to get groceries or to the doctor, and later with preparing meals or handling bills. [1]

Help has kinds as well. The form home health clinicians fill in separates a helper who sets up or cleans up, one who gives verbal cues or a steadying touch, and one who does part of the effort. Families don't need the form, only its plain habit: say what the help actually is. “Reminds him about the Tuesday pills” tells a professional more than “helps with his medication.” [4]

- For each activity, note what Dad does on his own, what he does with a hand, and whose hand it is.
- A list like this, filled in by the family, describes. It isn't a diagnosis and it isn't an assessment.

The health information he already has

Keep in one place what Dad's clinicians have already given him: any written instructions, and a current list of his medicines. The Family Caregiver Alliance says that list should include prescription drugs, over-the-counter medicines, vitamins, other nutritional products and herbal remedies, and that it should be shared with his doctors. [5]

Questions about his medicines go on a list of their own. The same guide tells caregivers who are concerned about any medication-related problem to contact the primary care provider and the pharmacist before anything is adjusted. For a family, that comes down to writing the question and changing nothing. [5]

Anything you've noticed about memory, mood, appetite or how he communicates goes down like everything else: one specific thing that happened, with its date. What you can't answer by watching becomes a question for the right clinician. The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests writing down everything you want to talk about before a visit, and taking notes during it. [5]

Two accounts, each with a name and a date

Dad's own account goes on the page first. AARP's guide is firm about it: a family caregiving plan must center on the wishes of the person receiving the care, and should never be made without their participation, knowledge and consent. [1]

Then add what the family has seen. Beside every note, put the date and whose it is: Dad said, your sister saw, the neighbor mentioned. Where his account and yours differ, write both and let the difference stand.

Mark what nobody has seen for themselves. Those are the things your care consultant, or his doctor, would want to confirm. The Family Caregiver Alliance describes professional care managers in general as trained to assess a family's individual situation. Your notes are what you bring to that. What the notes mean is theirs to say. [6]

What this means for your family

- A dated page can be set beside next year's page. A guess can't be set beside anything.
- Your part is to describe, with names and dates. Concluding and predicting aren't part of it.
- The help the family already gives belongs on the page, with roughly when each thing began.
- What a change means, and when Dad's situation should be looked at again, are questions for his doctor and the other professionals who know him.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say how Dad is doing, explain a medical condition, or forecast anything. The lists and definitions are from the sources below; the suggestions about what to write down are ours.

Ready for the next step?

You know what a baseline is for and what belongs in one. The care interview builds it with you: it asks about each area of Dad's daily life in turn, including the ones a family doesn't think to write down, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
2. Administration for Community Living, How Much Care Will You Need?
3. Administration for Community Living, What is Long-Term Care?
4. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, Outcome and Assessment Information Set Version E1 (OASIS-E1), All Items
5. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiver's Guide to Medications and Aging
6. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving at Home: A Guide to Community Resources